

TOPIC 1: SPEECH WORK

1. Revision of Speech Sounds

Review pure vowels, diphthongs and consonants learned earlier. Clear pronunciation supports listening and speaking in exams and daily life.

2. The Schwa /ə/

The schwa is the weak, unstressed vowel sound in words such as **about**, **doctor**, **above**, **teacher**. It is the most common vowel sound in English. Practise reducing unstressed syllables to /ə/.

3. Stress and Intonation

Word stress falls on particular syllables; sentence stress highlights important words. Intonation (rising/falling pitch) shows questions, statements and attitude. Incorrect stress can change meaning or make speech hard to follow.

4. Consonant Contrasts

- /l/ (leisure, garage, measure) vs /d/ (ledger, large, judge)
- /b/ (bird, term) vs /p/ (board, talk) – contrast long vowels
- /s/, /z/, /t/ – e.g. ceiling, short, cheque; sheep/chip, fish/pitch
- /w/ and /j/ – wet/yet, wine/year

Practise minimal pairs and listen carefully to models.

5. Summary

Master the schwa, stress, intonation and key consonant contrasts to improve clarity and comprehension in spoken English.

End of Topic 1